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2027 CYCLE

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CUET UG

Political Science

Disintegration of Second World & Bipolarity Collapse

Official Syllabus · Contemporary World Politics · Class 12 · CUET UG 2027 Cycle Notes

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Syllabus Alignment

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
The Soviet Model & Flaws	Nature of the Soviet system, economic stagnation, arms race, and the Afghan invasion.	Contrasting the Soviet state-planned economy with Western capitalism; evaluating the role of the 1917 Bolshevik Revolution and CPSU monopoly.
Gorbachev's Reforms	Gorbachev's reform policies (Glasnost & Perestroika); collapse of the Berlin Wall (1989).	Tracing how economic restructuring and political openness unleashed nationalist assertions in Eastern Europe and the Baltic republics.
Disintegration of the USSR	The August 1991 coup, declaration of dissolution in December 1991, and formation of the CIS.	Identifying the roles of Boris Yeltsin, Russia, Belarus, and Ukraine; recognizing Russia as the sole legal successor state in the UN Security Council.
Shock Therapy Debacle	Introduction of democratic politics and capitalism in post-communist regimes; Shock Therapy.	Analyzing the IMF/ World Bank shock therapy model, the "largest garage sale in history", currency collapse, and rise of the oligarchs.
Post-Communist Conflicts	New entities in world politics: Russia, Balkan states, Central Asian states, and regional tensions.	Mapping conflicts: Chechen rebellion, Tajikistan civil war, the violent disintegration of Yugoslavia, and the peaceful Czechoslovakian "Velvet Divorce".

Sub-topic	Official syllabus pointer (NTA CUET(UG) Political Science syllabus 2026, the current 2027 baseline — Contemporary World Politics)	Skills the questions test
India-Russia Strategic Ties	India's relations with Russia and other post-communist countries.	Detailing the 1971 Indo-Soviet Treaty, the 2000 Strategic Partnership Agreement, defense co-production (BrahMos), Kudankulam nuclear plant, and multipolar vision.

CUET UG Exam Strategy — Chapter 1 Focus (World Politics)

- **Pattern:** 50 Multiple Choice Questions (attempt any 40) in 60 minutes.
- **Marking:** +5 marks for correct choice, −1 mark negative deduction for incorrect choice.
- **High-Yield Angles:** Date of the fall of the Berlin Wall (9 Nov 1989), the three republics declaring USSR dissolved (Dec 1991), Baltic states vs CIS membership, consequences of Shock Therapy, and Indo-Russian defense milestones.

1. The Nature and Stagnation of the Soviet System

The Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) came into being following the **Bolshevik Revolution of 1917** in Russia, led by **Vladimir Lenin**. It was founded on socialist ideals prioritizing socio-economic equality and the abolition of private property.

Hallmarks of the Soviet System

- **Second World / Socialist Bloc:** After the Second World War, the countries of Eastern Europe liberated by the Soviet Red Army were incorporated into the Soviet sphere of influence under the **Warsaw Pact (1955)**, collectively known as the "Second World".
- **State-Controlled Planned Economy:**
  - All means of production, land, and factories were owned exclusively by the state; private property was outlawed.
  - The domestic industry produced everything from "pins to cars", insulating the economy from capitalist market fluctuations.
- **Guaranteed Social Safety Net:**
  - The Soviet state subsidized essential basic necessities: guaranteed employment, universal free healthcare, education, childcare, and subsidized housing.
  - There was virtually no unemployment in the formal Soviet economy.

Structural Weaknesses and Stagnation

- **Bureaucratic Authoritarianism:** The political system was monopolized by a single party—the **Communist Party of the Soviet Union (CPSU)**—which was unaccountable to the public, stifled free expression, and repressed political dissent.
- **Russian Chauvinism:** Although the USSR comprised 15 sovereign constituent republics, Russia dominated every cultural, political, and economic decision, alienating non-Russian nationalities.
- **Economic Burden of Arms Race:** To maintain military parity with the United States in the Cold War, the USSR diverted massive portions of its budget toward nuclear arsenals and conventional arms.
- **The Afghan Quagmire (1979–1989):** The Soviet military invasion of Afghanistan in December 1979 drained vital financial and military resources, triggering severe food shortages and industrial stagnation throughout the 1980s.

2. Mikhail Gorbachev's Reform Drive & Unintended Collapse

In March 1985, **Mikhail Gorbachev** became General Secretary of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union. He recognized that the USSR was falling behind the West in technology and living standards, and sought to modernize the system through managed reforms.

The Twin Pillars of Reform

- **Perestroika (Restructuring):** Economic decentralization aimed at introducing limited managerial autonomy, self-financing in state enterprises, and small private cooperatives.
- **Glasnost (Openness):** Freedom of expression, freedom of the press, transparency in government functioning, and the rehabilitation of victims of Stalinist purges.

Unintended Cascade of National Revolutions

- **Gorbachev's Miscalculation:** Gorbachev intended to strengthen socialism through democratic reforms. Instead, Glasnost allowed citizens to openly articulate long-suppressed ethnic resentments and nationalist aspirations.
- **Loss of Control in Eastern Europe:** Gorbachev announced that the USSR would no longer use military force to prop up communist puppet regimes in Eastern Europe (the end of the "Brezhnev Doctrine").
- **The Fall of the Berlin Wall (9 November 1989):**
  - Built in 1961 to divide East and West Berlin, the 150-km Berlin Wall was the physical embodiment of the Cold War iron curtain.
  - On 9 November 1989, ordinary East German citizens dismantled the wall with sledgehammers, sparking democratic revolutions across Poland, Hungary, Czechoslovakia, Romania, and Bulgaria.
  - Germany was officially reunified on **3 October 1990**.

3. The Collapse of the Soviet Union (1991)

The collapse of the Soviet Union unfolded with astonishing speed between 1989 and December 1991.

The August 1991 Coup and Rise of Boris Yeltsin

- **Coup Attempt (August 1991):** Communist Party hardliners and military intelligence chiefs staged a coup against Gorbachev to restore totalitarian control and derail his planned new Union Treaty.
- **Yeltsin's Popular Resistance: Boris Yeltsin**, popularly elected President of the Russian Republic, climbed atop a tank outside the Russian parliament building ("White House") in Moscow, rallying citizens against the coup plotters.
- **Shift of Power:** The coup collapsed within three days, permanently destroying the credibility of the Communist Party and transferring de facto sovereign power from Gorbachev to Yeltsin.

Formal Dissolution (December 1991)

- **The Belavezha Declaration:** In **December 1991**, under the leadership of Boris Yeltsin, the three core Slavic republics—**Russia, Ukraine, and Belarus**—formally declared that the Soviet Union was dissolved.
- **Establishment of the CIS:** Formed the **Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS)** to manage collective economic, nuclear, and military assets among successor states.
- **Gorbachev's Resignation:** On **25 December 1991**, Mikhail Gorbachev resigned as President of the USSR, and the red Soviet flag atop the Kremlin was replaced by the tricolor flag of the Russian Federation.
- **Russian Succession:**
  - Russia was accepted under international law as the **sole legal successor state** of the Soviet Union.
  - Russia inherited the USSR's permanent veto-bearing seat on the United Nations Security Council.
  - Russia took over all nuclear weapons from the other republics (Ukraine, Belarus, Kazakhstan relinquished their warheads under the 1994 Budapest Memorandum) and inherited Soviet treaty commitments.

Definition: The Baltic Republics Exception

The three Baltic republics—**Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania**—were the first to declare independence from the USSR in 1990. They completely refused to join the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) and formally joined the European Union (EU) and NATO in **2004**.

4. Shock Therapy in Post-Communist Regimes

Following the collapse of communism, the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and World Bank designed a painful transition program called **"Shock Therapy"** to rapidly convert centrally planned socialist economies into free-market capitalism.

Core Features of Shock Therapy

- **Total Privatisation:** Complete, rapid sale of state-owned enterprises, collective farms, and mineral assets to private entities.

- **Instant Price Deregulation:** Immediate abolition of state subsidies on food, housing, electricity, and transportation, letting market forces determine prices.
- **Currency Convertibility & Trade Opening:** Drastic reduction of import tariffs, total opening to foreign direct investment (FDI), and complete convertibility of national currencies.

Catastrophic Consequences of Shock Therapy

- **The "Largest Garage Sale in History":**
  - Roughly 90% of Russia's massive state-owned industrial enterprises were put on the auction block.
  - Citizens were given privatization vouchers with which to buy shares; however, impoverished citizens sold their vouchers on the black market to mafias and speculators.
  - Strategic factories worth billions were sold off at throwaway prices.
- **Collapse of the Russian Currency:** The Russian Ruble depreciated precipitously against the US dollar; runaway hyperinflation wiped out the lifetime bank savings of ordinary citizens.
- **Destruction of the Social Safety Net:**
  - The withdrawal of government subsidies pushed millions below the poverty line.
  - Academics, doctors, and scientists were reduced to penury, leading to a massive "brain drain" to the West.
- **Rise of the Russian Mafia and Oligarchs:**
  - Organized criminal gangs seized control of privatized banks, real estate, and retail markets.
  - A handful of well-connected financial tycoons (**the Oligarchs**) cornered Russia's oil, natural gas, aluminum, and nickel wealth.

5. Post-Communist Conflicts and Flashpoints

The removal of authoritarian Soviet control unleashed buried ethnic, regional, and territorial feuds across Eastern Europe, the Caucasus, and Central Asia.

Flashpoints in the Russian Federation

- **Chechnya and Dagestan:**
  - Violent secessionist insurgencies erupted in the Muslim-majority North Caucasus republics of Chechnya and Dagestan.
  - Russia launched two devastating wars in Chechnya (1994–1996 and 1999–2009), deploying indiscriminate artillery bombardments that flattened the capital city of Grozny.

Flashpoints in Central Asia

- **Tajikistan Civil War (1991–2001):** Endured a brutal decade-long civil war between rival regional and Islamist factions, claiming over 50,000 lives until a peace accord was brokered in 2001.

- **Geopolitical "New Great Game":** Vast hydrocarbon oil and gas reserves in the Caspian Sea basin attracted intense geopolitical rivalry among Russia, the United States, China, and regional powers for control over pipelines.
- **Nagorno-Karabakh:** Protracted territorial conflict between **Armenia and Azerbaijan** over the Armenian-majority enclave of Nagorno-Karabakh inside Azerbaijan.

Disintegration in Eastern Europe

- **Violent Balkanization of Yugoslavia:**
  - Yugoslavia fragmented along bitter ethnic lines as Slovenia, Croatia, and Bosnia-Herzegovina declared independence.
  - Serb-dominated Yugoslav forces carried out horrific ethnic cleansing and genocidal massacres against Bosnian Muslims, resulting in NATO air strikes in 1995 and 1999.
- **The Peaceful "Velvet Divorce" (1993):**
  - In stark contrast to the Balkan tragedy, Czechoslovakia divided peacefully and democratically into two sovereign nations: the **Czech Republic** and **Slovakia** on 1 January 1993.

6. India's Relations with Russia and Post-Communist States

Throughout the Cold War and into the post-Soviet era, relations between New Delhi and Moscow have remained exceptionally cordial, anchored in mutual strategic trust.

Historical Context: The Indo-Soviet Bond

- **Economic & Industrial Assistance:** The USSR financed and constructed India's foundational heavy public-sector industries, including steel plants at Bhilai and Bokaro, and heavy electrical manufacturing at Bharat Heavy Electricals Limited (BHEL).
- **Diplomatic Shield:** The Soviet Union repeatedly used its veto in the UN Security Council to block hostile Anglo-American resolutions on Kashmir (1957, 1965) and supported India's liberation of Goa (1961).
- **Indo-Soviet Treaty of Peace, Friendship and Cooperation (August 1971):** Signed during the Bangladesh Liberation War crisis, this 20-year mutual consultation pact provided India with military and diplomatic deterrence against US-Pakistan-China intervention.

Post-Cold War Strategic Partnership (2000 Onwards)

- **The Declaration of Strategic Partnership (October 2000):** Signed in New Delhi by Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee and Russian President Vladimir Putin, institutionalizing **annual bilateral leadership summits**.
- **Defense Cooperation:**
  - Over 60% of the Indian military's hardware, tanks, fighter aircraft, and naval submarines originate from Russia.
  - Transitioned from a simple buyer-seller relationship to **joint research and co-production**, highlighted by the world's fastest supersonic cruise missile, the **BrahMos** (jointly developed by DRDO and NPO Mashinostroyeniya).

- License production of Su-30MKI fighter jets, T-90 Bhishma main battle tanks, and the leasing of nuclear-powered attack submarines (INS Chakra).

- **Civil Nuclear Energy:** Russia constructed the 2,000 MW **Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant** in Tamil Nadu, supplying reactors and guaranteed enriched uranium fuel under IAEA safeguards.
- **Space Exploration:** Soviet space assistance dates back to the launching of India's first satellite **Aryabhata** (1975) and Rakesh Sharma's historic spaceflight (1984); Russia continues to support ISRO's human spaceflight program **Gaganyaan**.
- **Multipolar International Architecture:** Both nations champion a multipolar international order, collaborating in plurilateral platforms including **BRICS** and the **Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO)**.

The Whole Chapter in One Picture



Figure 1: Disintegration of the Second World Mindmap: Soviet system pillars, Gorbachev's reforms, dissolution sequence, Shock Therapy fallouts, and Indo-Russian strategic ties.

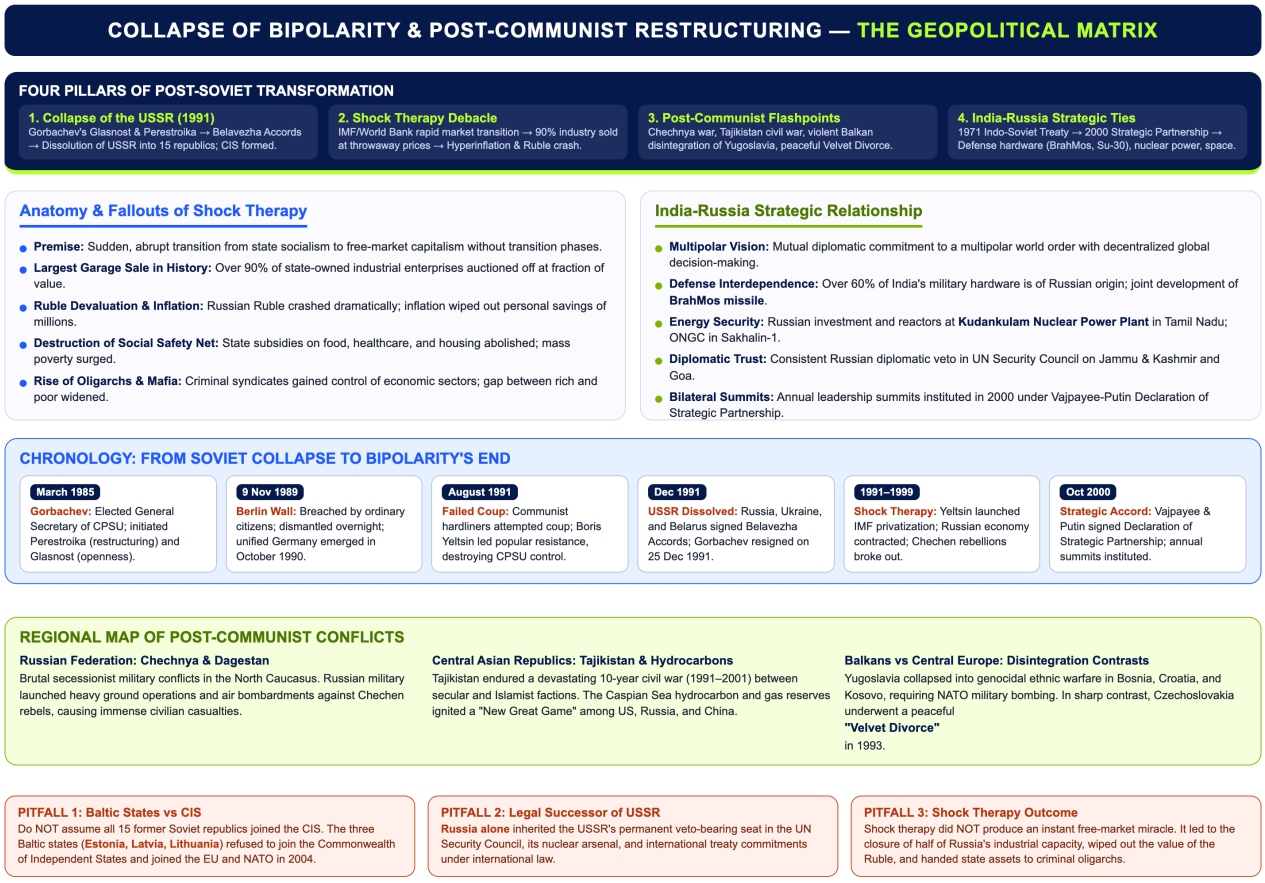


Figure 2: Collapse of Bipolarity Matrix: Transition chronology (1985–2000), Shock Therapy anatomy, post-communist conflict mapping, and legal succession realities.

Practice Questions (Exam Pattern)

Ten questions designed in authentic CUET UG single-correct style. The official marking scheme awards +5 for each correct answer and deducts −1 for every incorrect answer.

Q1. The Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) came into existence following the Bolshevik Revolution of 1917 under the leadership of which historic figure?

(A) Joseph Stalin
(B) Vladimir Lenin
(C) Leon Trotsky
(D) Nikita Khrushchev

Q2. In which year did the historic fall of the Berlin Wall take place, symbolizing the collapse of the Cold War division in Europe?

(A) 1985
(B) 1989
(C) 1990
(D) 1991

Q3. Which two reformist policies were introduced by Mikhail Gorbachev after becoming General Secretary of the Communist Party of the Soviet Union in 1985?

(A) Collectivisation and Industrialisation
(B) Perestroika and Glasnost
(C) New Economic Policy and Comintern
(D) Shock Therapy and Open Door Policy

Q4. In December 1991, which three key Slavic republics under Boris Yeltsin's leadership formally declared the dissolution of the Soviet Union?

(A) Russia, Kazakhstan, and Uzbekistan **(B)** Russia, Ukraine, and Belarus
(C) Russia, Georgia, and Armenia **(D)** Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania

Q5. Which of the following former Soviet republics completely refused to join the Commonwealth of Independent States (CIS) and instead joined NATO and the EU in 2004?

(A) Central Asian Republics **(B)** Caucasian Republics
(C) The Three Baltic Republics **(D)** Belarus and Ukraine

Q6. The painful process of rapid transition from a planned socialist economy to free-market capitalism sponsored by the IMF and World Bank was known as:

(A) Democratic Socialism **(B)** Perestroika
(C) Shock Therapy **(D)** Structural Hegemony

Q7. The large-scale, undervalued auctioning of roughly 90% of state-owned industries in post-Soviet Russia was popularly characterized as:

(A) The Great Leap Forward **(B)** The Largest Garage Sale in History
(C) The New Deal **(D)** The Marshall Plan of the East

Q8. The peaceful and democratic split of Czechoslovakia into the Czech Republic and Slovakia in January 1993 is historically remembered as the:

(A) Balkan Tragedy **(B)** Prague Spring
(C) Velvet Divorce **(D)** Orange Revolution

Q9. Tajikistan in Central Asia witnessed a devastating civil war following the collapse of the USSR that lasted for how many years?

(A) 3 years **(B)** 5 years
(C) 10 years **(D)** 15 years

Q10. The supersonic cruise missile 'BrahMos' represents a landmark defense joint venture between India and which foreign country?

(A) United States **(B)** France
(C) Israel **(D)** Russia

Detailed Solutions

Sol. Q1. Vladimir Lenin led the Bolshevik Revolution in Russia in October/November 1917, overthrowing the Tsarist regime and establishing the world's first socialist state, the USSR.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q2. The Berlin Wall, erected in 1961, was breached and pulled down by ordinary citizens on 9 November 1989, leading to the formal reunification of Germany in October 1990.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q3. Mikhail Gorbachev introduced Perestroika (economic restructuring) and Glasnost (political openness) to modernize the Soviet system, which inadvertently hastened its dissolution.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q4. In December 1991, the leaders of Russia (Boris Yeltsin), Ukraine (Leonid Kravchuk), and Belarus (Stanislav Shushkevich) signed the Belavezha Accords, formally declaring the USSR dissolved.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q5. The three Baltic states—Estonia, Latvia, and Lithuania—were the first to secede from the USSR in 1990, rejected CIS membership, and integrated with the West by joining NATO and the EU in 2004.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q6. Shock Therapy was the abrupt transition model prescribed by the International Monetary Fund and World Bank, imposing sweeping privatization and immediate price deregulation.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q7. The sell-off of over 90% of Russian state industries at throwaway voucher rates was famously described as 'the largest garage sale in history', resulting in economic plunder by oligarchs.

Answer: (B)

Sol. Q8. The amicable, bloodless partition of Czechoslovakia into the Czech Republic and Slovakia on 1 January 1993 is universally referred to by historians as the 'Velvet Divorce'.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q9. Tajikistan suffered a vicious sectarian and clan civil war that lasted for 10 years, from 1991 until a comprehensive peace accord was brokered with Russian mediation in 2001.

Answer: (C)

Sol. Q10. BrahMos (named after the Brahmaputra and Moskva rivers) is a world-class supersonic cruise missile developed jointly by India's DRDO and Russia's NPO Mashinostroyeniya.

Answer: (D)

Wrong-Answer Clinic — the one-line corrections

If you answered...	Your slip was...	The corrected rule, in one line
Q3 option D	Confusing Soviet reforms with Chinese or IMF terms	Perestroika/Glasnost were Soviet reforms; Shock Therapy was the IMF prescription; Open Door was Deng's policy in China.
Q4 option D	Confusing Baltic states with the Slavic founders	The Baltic states broke away first in 1990; Russia, Ukraine, and Belarus dissolved the USSR in Dec 1991.
Q5 option D	Assuming Belarus and Ukraine rejected the CIS	Belarus and Ukraine were co-founders of the CIS; only the three Baltic states refused to join.
Q8 option B	Picking the 1968 reform movement	The Prague Spring was in 1968 (crushed by Soviets); the Velvet Divorce was the 1993 peaceful separation.
Q9 option B	Underestimating the length of Tajikistan's civil war	Tajikistan's civil war raged for a full decade (1991–2001).

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